

Quine and Strawson — Solved Answer-Writing Workbook and Toolkit

Ten verified PYQs and three original solved answers

Every answer is independent learner practice and never official UPSC answer keys.
Exact verified wording is used for the ten primary-owned PYQs through 2026. Cross-links do not inflate ownership.

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Demand map and timed bands

Marks	Suggested time	Working answer band	Required movement
10	7–8 minutes	150–300 words	define, derive, one qualification, verdict
15	10–11 minutes	250–400 words	thesis, mechanism, evaluation, qualified close
20	14–15 minutes	330–550 words	multi-limb argument, objection/reply, developed judgement

Reusable answer spine

DIRECTIVE -> PRECISE THESIS -> DOCTRINAL MECHANISM -> TEXT/EXAMPLE
-> OBJECTION -> QUALIFICATION -> DEMAND-SPECIFIC VERDICT

Do not merge Quine's naturalized holism with Strawson's descriptive metaphysics. In comparison answers, name the shared pressure and then restore the difference in method, unit of analysis and ambition.

1. 2018 Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Cover logically primitive concept, M-predicates, self-ascription requires other-ascription; close with blocks Cartesian dualism.

Time guidance: 7–8 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson explains the person not as a compound of mind and body but as a **logically primitive concept** - the concept of a single subject to which we ascribe both bodily and mental predicates, and which is presupposed by, rather than assembled from, the concepts of a pure ego and a pure body (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3).

The predicate matrix. A person is that to which we ascribe both **M-predicates** - properties we also ascribe to mere material bodies ("weighs 70 kg", "is in the corner") - and **P-predicates** - states of consciousness and action ascribable only to persons ("is in pain", "believes that p", "is going for a walk"). The mark of a P-predicate is its **asymmetry**: it is ascribed to others on the basis of observed behaviour, but to oneself without observation or criteria.

The argument (self-ascription requires other-ascription). I can ascribe P-predicates to myself only if the same predicates are ascribable to others; to ascribe them to others I must identify others as single subjects of both M- and P-predicates. Hence the concept of such a subject - a person - is presupposed by the very possibility of self-ascription, and is therefore primitive.

Consequence. This blocks Cartesian dualism (two independent substances could not be the single subject our predicate-practice requires, and other minds would become unknowable) and the no-ownership theory (which cannot state its own claim without covertly reintroducing ownership).

Verdict. The person concept is the indispensable middle term between mind and body; treating either as prior mislocates the foundation.

Measured model-answer words: 248

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move "blocks Cartesian dualism" and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: logically primitive concept; M-predicates; self-ascription requires other-ascription; blocks Cartesian dualism.

2. 2018 Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: How does Quine show that the notion of a priori knowledge as discussed by Kant is 'a metaphysical article of faith'? Give reasons for your answer.

Demand decoding: Cover analytic/synthetic boundary, confirmation is holistic, naturalism denies; close with Strawson's descriptive-metaphysics.

Time guidance: 10–11 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Quine's charge that Kant's *a priori* is "a metaphysical article of faith" is the conclusion of three connected moves: there is no principled analytic/synthetic boundary; confirmation is holistic, so no statement is a priori *by nature*; and naturalism denies any first-philosophy standpoint from which the a priori could be certified. Kant's a priori therefore rests on an undischarged assumption - an article of faith.

Move 1 - the analytic/synthetic circle. Kant's synthetic a priori presupposes a clear analytic/synthetic distinction. In "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951) Quine shows analyticity can be explained only through synonymy, definition, interchangeability *salva veritate*, necessity and semantical rules - with circularity in the synonymy routes and residual unclarity about the general rule notion. The boundary cannot be drawn non-circularly, so the empiricist attempt to insulate a priori truth through analyticity loses its foundation; Kant's synthetic a priori is pressured by holism rather than refuted by definition alone.

Move 2 - holism. Because beliefs "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body" (the web of belief), *any* statement can be held true come what may, and none is immune to revision - even logic. Once the analytic-synthetic foundation fails, centrality explains differential practical revisability within the web; it does not redefine analyticity or apriority.

Move 3 - naturalism. Philosophy is continuous with science, not its a priori tribunal; there is no external vantage from which to guarantee a priori knowledge. To assert it is therefore to take on trust exactly what cannot be shown - "a metaphysical article of faith".

Objection and reply. Kant can respond that transcendental conditions of experience are not empirical hypotheses inside the web, so holistic revisability does not touch them (Strawson's descriptive-metaphysics reading protects a framework role). Quine's rejoinder: that reply reasserts a privileged non-empirical status which is precisely the article of faith in question.

Verdict. Quine succeeds against a *sharp* a priori/a posteriori boundary. A gradient of entrenchment explains why some commitments are harder to revise in practice; it neither restores nor redefines an analytic or Kantian a priori class. Whether *some* framework role escapes the web remains the live issue, kept separate from the Kant paper's own defence.

Measured model-answer words: 365

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move "Strawson's descriptive-metaphysics" and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: analytic/synthetic boundary; confirmation is holistic; naturalism denies; Strawson's descriptive-metaphysics.

3. 2019 Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction.

Demand decoding: Cover Quine argues that the analytic/synthetic distinction, synonymy and interchangeability; close by explaining that agreed examples do not supply a non-circular criterion and that centrality explains revisability rather than analyticity.

Time guidance: 7–8 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: Credit requires the circularity argument, the Grice-Strawson reply and a precise conclusion. Treating maximal centrality or entrenchment as Quine's new definition of analyticity loses conceptual-accuracy marks; centrality belongs only to the later explanation of differential practical revisability.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Quine argues that the analytic/synthetic distinction cannot be drawn by any principled, **non-circular** criterion; every proposed explanation of "analytic" presupposes a notion from the same family. His conclusion is precise: not that no sentence *seems* analytic, but that there is no principled boundary marking a class of truths true *by meaning alone*.

The circle of meaning (reproduce it). (1) Analytic truths divide into logical truths and those reducible to logical truths by substituting **synonyms**; so analyticity needs **synonymy**. (2) Synonymy might be explained by **definition** - but a good definition *reports* an antecedent synonymy, so this is circular. (3) Or by **interchangeability *salva veritate*** - but in an extensional language this over-generates (coextensive terms like "creature with a heart"/"creature with a kidney" interchange without being synonymous), and adding "necessarily" to fix it presupposes **necessity**, which for Quine is intelligible only *via* analyticity. (4) Or by **semantic rules** in an artificial language - but these merely list what is to *count* as analytic, without saying what analyticity *is*. Every road returns to the start.

Analysis. The dogma survives only as an unexplained primitive. After its proposed foundation fails, centrality explains differential practical revisability within the web; it does not redefine analyticity or convert highly entrenched sentences into a replacement analytic class.

Objection and reply. Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) argue that a distinction in ordinary use with agreed examples is not discredited merely because no reductive definition is available. Quine's reply: agreed examples do not supply the *principled behavioural boundary* the epistemology of logical empiricism required.

Verdict. Quine wins where the distinction was load-bearing (the verification principle, the linguistic theory of necessity); the exact result is the failure of a non-circular criterion, not the denial that "bachelors are unmarried" looks analytic.

Measured model-answer words: 294

Qualification / criticism: The answer preserves the limiting moves "agreed examples do not supply" and "does not redefine analyticity"; it uses centrality only to explain differential practical revisability.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: Quine argues that the analytic/synthetic distinction; synonymy; interchangeability; agreed examples do not supply; centrality explains differential practical revisability; does not redefine analyticity.

4. 2020 Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars.

Demand decoding: Cover spatio-temporal thinking is a precondition, re-identify, material bodies; close with auditory world.

Time guidance: 10–11 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. For Strawson, **spatio-temporal thinking is a precondition of objective thinking itself**: we can think of a world of particulars that exist independently of our experience only because we can locate and re-locate them in a single public spatio-temporal framework - and material bodies, his basic particulars,

are what constitute that framework (*Individuals*, 1959).

Objectivity and re-identification. Objective thought requires the distinction between "how things are" and "how they seem to me". That distinction has a use only if I can **re-identify** particulars - judge "this is the same one I encountered before" - across gaps in observation. Re-identification in turn requires a **single, unified system of space and time** within which a thing traces a continuous career.

Why material bodies are basic. Bodies are three-dimensional, relatively enduring and publicly located; they compose the one spatio-temporal system, and every more shadowy particular (a sound, a flash, a private sensation) is identified only by reference to bodies and their positions. So bodies are the **basic particulars** - identifiable without first identifying anything else - and spatio-temporal thinking is built into objective thought.

The no-space test. Strawson's purely **auditory world** asks whether a non-spatial being could sustain re-identification. His answer: only by constructing a sound-analogue of space (a "master-sound" whose pitch fixes position) - which supports the need for an individuating framework without proving that every scheme contains our exact spatial/material organisation.

Objection and reply. Evans and others argue the auditory construction may smuggle in spatial notions or fall short of genuine re-identification, and that a merely temporal framework might suffice. Reply: even the minimal construction must reintroduce something that plays space's *individuating* role, which is the substantive claim.

Verdict. Spatio-temporal thinking is not a convenient tool for finding things but a **transcendental condition** of there being objective particulars to think about; the dependence claim survives the objections.

Measured model-answer words: 301

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move "auditory world" and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: spatio-temporal thinking is a precondition; re-identify; material bodies; auditory world.

5. 2021 Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding: Cover identified without first identifying, spatio-temporal system, primitive; close with co-basic.

Time guidance: 10–11 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Basic particulars are the particulars that can be **identified without first identifying anything else**; Strawson argues that **material bodies** and **persons** are the two basic categories, because both are required for the single public framework in which objective particular-identification is possible (*Individuals*, 1959).

Material bodies. Objective thought requires **re-identification** of particulars, which requires a **single, unified spatio-temporal system**; material bodies - three-dimensional, enduring and publicly located - provide its standard public anchors, and every other particular (events, processes, private experiences) is identified by reference to them. Hence bodies are basic. The **auditory-world** discussion tests this: re-identification without space is possible only by building a space-analogue.

Persons. Persons are the *second* basic particular because the concept of a person is **primitive** - a single subject of both **M-predicates** (also true of bodies) and **P-predicates** (states of consciousness, ascribed to others on behavioural criteria, to oneself without observation). Since **self-ascription of P-predicates requires other-ascription**, and other-ascription requires identifying others as embodied subjects, persons cannot be reduced to bodies-plus-egos; they are irreducibly basic.

Critical discussion. (i) Are persons genuinely *co-basic* with bodies, or dependent on them (since persons are a kind of body)? Strawson's answer: persons are not *reducible* to bodies because P-predicates cannot be analysed in purely bodily terms, so both categories are needed. (ii) Evans-type objections to the auditory world; (iii) whether the argument establishes *primitiveness* or only *co-instantiation* of the mental and bodily.

Verdict. The dual thesis holds: bodies ground the spatio-temporal framework, persons ground the subject of experience, and neither category can be dissolved into the other without losing the conditions of objective thought.

Measured model-answer words: 263

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move "co-basic" and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: identified without first identifying; spatio-temporal system; primitive; co-basic.

6. 2021 Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: Critically examine Quine's postulate of empiricism without the dogmas with reference to his 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding: Cover holistic empiricism, two dogmas, web; close with minimum mutilation.

Time guidance: 10–11 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. "Empiricism without the dogmas" is Quine's positive doctrine: once the two dogmas are abandoned, what remains is a **holistic empiricism** in which experience still governs belief, but the whole web of belief - not the individual sentence - faces the tribunal of experience (*Two Dogmas of Empiricism*, 1951).

The two dogmas removed. Dogma 1, the **analytic/synthetic distinction**, fails because "analytic" has no non-circular criterion (definition/synonymy routes are circular, interchangeability needs intensional resources, and the general semantical-rule notion remains unclear). Dogma 2, **reductionism** - the belief that each meaningful statement is equivalent to a construction upon terms referring to immediate experience, so that each has its own range of confirming experiences - fails because no statement is confirmed in isolation.

The positive residue - holism. Our beliefs form a **web** or "field of force" that impinges on experience only at its edges; a recalcitrant experience forces readjustment *somewhere*, but which statements to revise is **underdetermined** by experience, so "no statement is immune to revision" and "any statement can be held true come what may". This is the **Duhem-Quine** point: a hypothesis meets experience only conjoined with auxiliaries. Empiricism survives as the thesis that experience is the only check on belief; what is dropped is the atomistic idea that it checks sentences one by one.

Objection and reply. (i) Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) argue Quine has not shown the analytic/synthetic distinction is *unreal*, only undefined - so the residue may be an overreach. (ii) If any statement can be saved, does holism license irrationalism? Reply: revision is disciplined by pragmatic virtues - **minimum mutilation**, conservatism, simplicity - so holism is not "anything goes". (iii) Centrality and periphery explain unequal practical resistance to revision; they do not restore analyticity by degrees.

Verdict. The postulate is coherent and powerful: empiricism is *reformed*, not abandoned - experience governs the corporate body of belief holistically - but its cost is the loss of any sharp a priori/empirical line, replaced by gradients of entrenchment.

Measured model-answer words: 327

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move "minimum mutilation" and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: holistic empiricism; two dogmas; web; minimum mutilation.

7. 2023 Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Cover primitive concept, M-predicates, self-ascription argument; close with no-ownership theory.

Time guidance: 14–15 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson considers **person** a *primitive* concept because it cannot be analysed as a composite of a pure Cartesian ego and a material body; rather, the concept of a single subject bearing both bodily and mental predicates is **logically prior** to, and presupposed by, both. Its chief implication is the collapse of mind-body dualism, since two independent substances could not be the one subject our predicate-practice demands (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3, "Persons").

1. What "primitive" means. To call the person concept primitive is to deny that it is *definable* in terms of the concept of a pure consciousness plus the concept of a body. Those two concepts are, for Strawson, *later abstractions* from the person concept, not its constituents; the Cartesian order of analysis is inverted.

2. The predicate matrix. We ascribe to one and the same individual both **M-predicates** (also true of mere bodies - "weighs 70 kg", "is in the room") and **P-predicates** (states of consciousness and action - "is in pain", "believes", "is going for a walk"). P-predicates are **asymmetric**: ascribed to others on behavioural criteria, to oneself without observation. That a single concept carries predicates of this double character is the central datum.

3. The self-ascription argument. (i) I ascribe P-predicates to myself. (ii) A predicate I ascribe to myself must be one I can ascribe to others. (iii) To ascribe P-predicates to others I must identify them as single subjects of both M- and P-predicates. (iv) Therefore the concept of such a subject - a person - is presupposed by self-ascription itself; it is primitive.

4. Implication for dualism. On dualism the real subject is an immaterial ego and the body a separate substance. Then P-predicates would attach to an ego I can never observe in others, so I could neither learn nor apply them - and so could not self-ascribe them either; and two logically independent substances could not be the *single* subject our practice requires. Dualism makes other minds unknowable and P-ascription unintelligible. **The mirror error - the no-ownership theory** (Lichtenberg's "it thinks" for Descartes's "I think") - is equally blocked: it cannot state that experiences depend on *this* body rather than that without covertly using "my", reintroducing the ownership it denies. So experiences are necessarily owned by a person.

5. Objections and reply. (i) Does the argument prove *primitiveness*, or only that the mental and bodily are *co-instantiated*? Strawson: mere co-instantiation would not explain the asymmetric logic of P-predicates, which requires a single subject-concept. (ii) Ayer defended a version of the no-ownership view; Strawson's self-reference point answers it. (iii) The behavioural-criteria premise risks logical behaviourism; Strawson insists behaviour is *critical evidence*, not the *meaning* of P-predicates.

Verdict. The person is the indispensable middle term between mind and body; dualism and no-ownership both fail because each denies the single subject that the logic of P-predicates presupposes. What survives even under the co-instantiation worry is that any adequate scheme must treat the person, not the ego or the body, as basic.

Measured model-answer words: 490

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move "no-ownership theory" and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: primitive concept; M-predicates; self-ascription argument; no-ownership theory.

8. 2024 Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the nature of the two dogmas that Quine refers to in his paper 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding: Cover analytic/synthetic distinction, reductionism, at root identical; close with holism.

Time guidance: 10–11 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The two dogmas Quine attacks in "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951) are (1) the belief in a fundamental **analytic/synthetic distinction**, and (2) **reductionism** - the belief that every meaningful statement is equivalent to some logical construction upon terms referring to immediate experience. Quine argues both are ill-founded and that they are "at root identical".

Dogma 1 - the analytic/synthetic distinction. The claim is that some truths are true *by meaning* (analytic) and others *by fact* (synthetic). Quine shows "analytic" can be explained only through a circle of interdefinable notions - **synonymy, definition, interchangeability *salva veritate*, necessity and semantical rules** - the first routes are circular while the general rule notion remains unclear. No non-circular criterion exists, so the distinction lacks the principled basis empiricism claimed for it. His precise conclusion is the absence of a boundary, not the denial that some sentences seem analytic.

Dogma 2 - reductionism. In its radical form (Locke, Hume, early Carnap's *Aufbau*) each statement has its *own* unique range of confirming or infirming experiences - **verificationism at the level of the individual sentence**. Quine argues no statement is confirmed in isolation: statements meet experience only in concert (the **Duhem-Quine** point), so the idea of statement-by-statement verification collapses.

Why the two dogmas are "at root identical". The analytic/synthetic distinction and reductionism are two sides of one verificationist theory of meaning: an analytic statement is the limiting case of one confirmed "come what may" (empty confirmation-conditions), while reductionism assigns each synthetic statement its private confirmation-conditions. Reject individual verification and both the sharp analytic pole and the reductionist picture fall together.

Consequence - holism. What replaces them is **confirmation holism**: belief faces "the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body" (the web of belief), and no statement is immune to revision. This is "empiricism without the dogmas".

Verdict. The nature of the two dogmas is that both are unearned commitments of logical empiricism's theory of meaning; dismantling individual verificationism removes both at once and yields holism.

Measured model-answer words: 333

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move "holism" and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: analytic/synthetic distinction; reductionism; at root identical; holism.

9. 2025 Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." Discuss this statement in the light of Quine's 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding: Cover quotation, come what may and minimum mutilation; close with change of subject and explicitly distinguish practical entrenchment from analyticity.

Time guidance: 10–11 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: Credit requires the quoted holist claim, the conjunction logic, pragmatic constraints and later logical caution. Deduct conceptual-accuracy marks if the answer calls central statements analytic: entrenchment explains differential practical revisability after the analytic-synthetic foundation fails.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The quotation - "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere" - states Quine's **confirmation holism**: because belief confronts experience only as a whole, any statement can be retained under any evidence, provided compensating revisions are made elsewhere in the web (*Two Dogmas of Empiricism*, 1951).

The web of belief. Our beliefs form a **field of force** or web whose boundary conditions are experience. A conflict with experience occasions readjustment *somewhere in the interior*, but "the total field is so underdetermined by its boundary conditions ... that there is much latitude of choice as to what statements to re-evaluate". Hence "**no statement is immune to revision**", and, conversely, any statement can be held true "**come what may**".

Why it is true - the Duhem-Quine mechanism. A hypothesis H predicts an observation O only with auxiliaries A: $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$. If O fails, logic yields only NOT-(H & A) - *something* in the package is false, but not *which*. So one may always protect H by revising A (or even, at the extreme, by "pleading hallucination" or revising a law of logic). Refutation is never decisive against a single sentence; that is the exact ground of the quotation.

Consequences. (i) The analytic/synthetic distinction loses its proposed foundation. Centrality and entrenchment explain differential practical revisability; they do not redefine analyticity or create an analytic class by degree. (ii) There is no sentence-by-sentence verification, so the second dogma falls. (iii) The distribution of revision costs is pragmatic rather than a replacement a priori taxonomy.

Objection and reply. Does holism license irrationalism - if we may hold anything true, is theory-choice arbitrary? Reply: revision is disciplined by **pragmatic virtues** - **minimum mutilation**, conservatism, simplicity, generality, fecundity. We *may* save any sentence, but at a rational *cost*; central logical laws are

given up only under enormous pressure (cf. the debate over revising logic for quantum mechanics - Birkhoff and von Neumann 1936; Putnam 1968 - and Quine's caution about "change of subject"). So "any statement come what may" describes what is *logically possible*, constrained by what is *pragmatically reasonable*.

Verdict. The statement is not a licence for caprice but a precise consequence of holism: experience constrains the web globally, not sentence by sentence, so rational revision is a matter of balancing conservatism against simplicity across the whole system.

Measured model-answer words: 398

Qualification / criticism: The answer contains "change of subject" and states that centrality and entrenchment explain differential practical revisability rather than analyticity.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: quotation; come what may; minimum mutilation; change of subject; differential practical revisability; do not redefine analyticity.

10. 2026 Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: Why are states of consciousness ascribed to anything at all and why are they ascribed to the same things to which we also ascribe physical properties? How does Strawson answer these questions in his work *Individuals*?

Demand decoding: Cover Strawson asks how predicates of consciousness, same subject, self-ascription requires; close with States of consciousness and physical properties are ascribed.

Time guidance: 14–15 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson asks how predicates of consciousness can have subjects at all and why those subjects are the very individuals to whom bodily predicates apply. In *Individuals* he answers through the logically primitive concept of a **person**: one identifiable particular that is the subject of both physical or M-predicates and psychological or P-predicates.

Why states of consciousness are ascribed. A state such as pain, belief or intention is not treated as an ownerless event. Its grammar requires possible self-ascription and other-ascription. The predicate "is in pain" is self-ascribed without observing one's behaviour, yet it is also ascribed to another person through public behavioural and situational criteria. A predicate could not possess this double use if it applied only to a private ego available to one subject.

Why the same things receive physical predicates. Other persons must be identified and re-identified in the public spatio-temporal framework. The individual encountered as walking, speaking and occupying a place is the same subject who is said to hope, suffer or decide. Thus one subject bears M-predicates such as location and weight and P-predicates such as thought and sensation. The concept of a person is logically prior to separate abstractions of body and consciousness.

Argument and other minds. Self-ascription requires that predicates of the same type can be other-ascribed; other-ascription requires embodied, publicly identifiable subjects. This avoids an analogical inference from a visible body to a hidden Cartesian mind. Behaviour is criterial evidence for third-person use, not a reduction of experience to behaviour.

Implication and qualification. Cartesian dualism starts with two independently identifiable substances and then cannot explain their single subjecthood. The no-ownership theory also fails because relating a class of experiences to this body rather than another covertly restores the person. Strawson establishes conceptual priority, however, not a causal mechanism of psychophysical unity. His answer dissolves the faulty starting point more clearly than it solves every metaphysical problem of consciousness.

Verdict. States of consciousness and physical properties are ascribed to the same things because the person, not an ego-body aggregate, is the primitive bearer that makes both forms of predication possible.

Measured model-answer words: 347

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move “States of consciousness and physical properties are ascribed” and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: Strawson asks how predicates of consciousness; same subject; self-ascription requires; States of consciousness and physical properties are ascribed.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain how Quine's confirmation holism follows from his rejection of the two dogmas of empiricism.

Demand decoding: Cover positive result, hypothesis together with auxiliaries, corporate body; close with minimum mutilation.

Time guidance: 7–8 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

Quine's confirmation holism is not an independent add-on to *Two Dogmas*; it is the positive result reached when both dogmas fail. The first dogma separates analytic truths, allegedly secured by meaning, from synthetic truths answerable to fact. Quine shows that analyticity cannot be explicated without circular appeal to synonymy, definition, necessity or semantical rules. The second dogma assigns each meaningful synthetic sentence its own confirming experiences. Quine denies that isolation because a prediction follows only from a hypothesis together with auxiliaries and background assumptions.

If experience conflicts with a prediction, logic yields only that something in the conjunction must change. It does not identify one guilty sentence. Consequently, statements face experience “as a corporate body”: a web whose periphery is more directly disturbed by observation while logic and mathematics remain centrally entrenched. No sentence is immune in principle, yet revision is constrained by conservatism,

simplicity and minimum mutilation. Holism therefore preserves empiricism while rejecting atomistic confirmation: experience governs the total system, not one sentence at a time. The result is a graded, pragmatically managed web rather than an “anything goes” relativism.

Measured model-answer words: 181

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move “minimum mutilation” and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: positive result; hypothesis together with auxiliaries; corporate body; minimum mutilation.

Original 2 · 15 marks

Question: “Strawson's persons and Quine's web of belief are two forms of one anti-Cartesian conviction.” Critically discuss.

Demand decoding: Cover real convergence, primitive subject, positive projects diverge; close with Convergence without conflation.

Time guidance: 10–11 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

The comparison captures a real convergence but becomes false if it erases method. Quine's web rejects the Cartesian hope for an unrevisable foundation outside science. Beliefs face experience corporately, and inquiry repairs Neurath's boat from within. Naturalized epistemology continues this anti-first-philosophy move by treating knowing as a natural process rather than the deliverance of an isolated pure reason.

Strawson's person doctrine rejects a different Cartesian priority. A person is not assembled from an independently identifiable body and private ego; the person is the primitive subject of both M-predicates and P-predicates. Because self-ascription of psychological predicates requires their possible other-ascription to publicly identifiable subjects, the hidden ego cannot ground the practice. Both philosophers therefore oppose an epistemically or semantically self-sufficient private item.

Yet their positive projects diverge. Quine is naturalistic, revisionary and scientifically regimenting; his web is revisable under experience and pragmatic virtues. Strawson practises descriptive metaphysics: he maps conditions internal to our existing conceptual scheme, including enduring bodies and persons. Quine is suspicious of determinate meaning and reference, while Strawson relies on stable public practices of identification and predication. Grice and Strawson even defend ordinary analytic-synthetic contrast-cases against Quine.

The anti-Cartesian label is therefore useful at the level of target: neither starts from a private given or an external foundation. It is misleading at the level of doctrine. One reforms empiricism through holism and naturalism; the other describes a public framework of particulars and persons. Convergence without

conflation is the defensible verdict. This separation also keeps distinct their standards of success: predictive scientific continuity for Quine and faithful conceptual description for Strawson.

Measured model-answer words: 262

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move “Convergence without conflation” and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: real convergence; primitive subject; positive projects diverge; Convergence without conflation.

Original 3 · 20 marks

Question: Assess the claim that both Quine and Strawson refute classical empiricism, but at different levels.

Demand decoding: Cover ownership qualification, conceptual conditions, levels differ; close with methodologically and doctrinally distinct.

Time guidance: 14–15 minutes, including roughly one minute for demand decoding and a final qualification check.

Marks logic: The answer earns content credit only if each printed limb is developed; terminology, causal connection, criticism and a qualified verdict are weighted above decorative quotation.

Timed independent model answer

The claim is defensible only with an ownership qualification. Quine directly supplies the printed critique of empiricism; Strawson's primary printed task is positive—theories of basic particulars and persons—although those theories pressure private sense-datum and no-ownership starting points.

Quine attacks empiricism internally. Dogma one separates analytic truth from synthetic fact, but proposed explications through synonymy, definition, interchangeability, necessity and semantical rules remain circular or insufficiently explanatory. Dogma two gives each sentence a private range of confirming experiences. The Duhem-Quine structure shows instead that a hypothesis yields observation only with auxiliaries, so recalcitrant experience underdetermines which statement to revise. Confirmation therefore belongs to the corporate web. Experience survives as constraint, but a priori immunity and atomistic verification do not. Naturalized epistemology then rejects a tribunal outside science.

Strawson challenges an empiricist reconstruction at the level of conceptual conditions. Objective identification requires re-identification in one public spatio-temporal framework; private, momentary sense-data cannot provide its enduring anchors, whereas material bodies can. Persons are primitive subjects of both physical and psychological predicates. Self-ascription depends on possible other-ascription to embodied subjects, so neither a private Cartesian ego nor ownerless experiences can be conceptually prior.

The levels differ. Quine revises a theory of meaning, confirmation and inquiry from within natural science. Strawson descriptively reconstructs conditions of reference, predication and personal ascription in our scheme. His result does not prove a mind-independent ontology, and Quine's holism does not entail that

every revision is equally rational. Moreover, Strawson and Grice defend an ordinary analytic-synthetic distinction, blocking the fiction of a united school.

Critics can press both sides. Grice and Strawson argue that familiar contrast-cases need no reductive definition; naturalized epistemology may lose normativity. Strawson may merely redescribe psychophysical unity and may show only what our scheme presupposes, not what reality must contain.

Thus Quine refutes classical empiricism's dogmatic architecture directly, while Strawson undermines private-data reconstruction indirectly through public identification and personhood. Their arguments converge against atomism and privacy but remain methodologically and doctrinally distinct. The final comparison must therefore preserve separate methods, separate primary burdens and separate standards of philosophical success.

Measured model-answer words: 344

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move “methodologically and doctrinally distinct” and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: ownership qualification; conceptual conditions; levels differ; methodologically and doctrinally distinct.

Final self-check

- Did the answer follow the exact directive rather than merely describe the thinker?
- Did every quotation perform argumentative work?
- Did the final judgement preserve scope, ownership and the strongest limitation?
- Did a Quine answer distinguish holism, naturalism, commitment and translation doctrines?
- Did a Strawson answer distinguish basic bodies, primitive persons and the separate referring debate?